Rosterforge

Rosterforge Executive Summary

Problem

Small and mid-sized caterers run on thin margins and tight timelines, and their largest operational risk is a short-staffed event. In interviews with 31 caterers and event-staffing managers in our university's metro area, 26 said they had experienced a same-week staffing gap in the previous quarter, and 19 said they had lost revenue or paid rush premiums because of one. A typical event needs between four and fifteen part-time workers, such as bartenders, servers, and setup or breakdown crews. Cancellations of 10 to 15 percent are normal, and most caterers fill the gaps through group text threads, calls to former employees, and referrals. This is slow, depends on a few individuals, and leaves no record of who is reliable. Payment is a second friction: workers are paid by cash or by payroll that arrives one to two weeks after the shift, which makes the best workers less willing to take short-notice work.

Solution

Rosterforge is a mobile and web app that turns an unfilled shift into a filled one within hours. A caterer posts a shift with role, start time, duration, location and hourly rate. The app notifies matching workers who have set their availability and role preferences, ranks them by proximity, past ratings and reliability, and confirms the first acceptance. On the day, workers check in with a location-verified tap. When the caterer confirms hours at the end of the shift, the worker is paid immediately through a payments partner, and the caterer is billed the same amount plus our fee. Caterers can also build a private roster of favorite workers who are offered shifts first, which gives them the convenience of their existing contacts with the reach of a larger pool.

Market

We are starting with caterers serving weddings, corporate events and private parties in a single metropolitan area. Using public industry counts and our interviews, we estimate roughly 420 catering businesses in our launch metro, of which about 250 employ part-time event staff. If the average such caterer books 60 events per year and fills eight roles per event, the metro represents about 120,000 shifts per year. At an average shift value of 140 dollars, that is roughly 16.8 million dollars in annual labor spend in our beachhead market. Our national estimate, scaling by population from the same assumptions, is a staffing spend in the low billions of dollars. These figures are rough, built from a small interview sample, and we plan to refine them during the pilot.

Business Model

We charge caterers a service fee of 12 percent of the shift's labor cost, collected on top of worker pay, and workers pay nothing. Early pricing is based on conversations rather than tests, and we expect to adjust it after the pilot. At an average shift value of 140 dollars, revenue is about 16.80 dollars per shift before payment-processing costs of roughly 2.5 percent, leaving a contribution margin near 13 dollars per shift. A caterer filling 40 shifts per month through Rosterforge would generate about 520 dollars in monthly contribution. We assume an acquisition cost of 400 dollars per caterer through direct outreach and referrals, which implies a payback of under one month if usage reaches that level. We have not yet validated that usage level beyond our first client. We may later add a premium tier with roster analytics and compliance tools.

Competition

The space is crowded. General-purpose shift-scheduling tools serve restaurants and retail but do not supply workers. On-demand staffing marketplaces supply workers across many industries but tend to focus on warehousing and hospitality agencies with minimum contracts and higher fees. Traditional staffing agencies charge markups of 30 to 50 percent and respond in days.

Finally, caterers' informal networks are free and familiar, and they are our most significant competitor. Our differentiation is a narrow focus on event roles, a same-day matching workflow, instant worker payment, and the ability to bring a caterer's own workers onto the platform. We recognize that larger marketplaces could add similar features, and our defensibility will depend on local density of workers and caterers and on switching costs created by caterers' saved rosters and records.

Team

Maya Okonkwo-Reyes, chief executive officer, is a senior in business administration who worked three summers as a banquet captain and catering coordinator, and has personally dealt with last-minute staffing gaps. Daniel Brandvold, chief technology officer, is a senior in computer science who built the prototype and previously interned as a mobile developer. Priya Venkataraman, chief operating officer, is a master's student in operations management who leads worker vetting, caterer onboarding and payments integration. We have no outside advisors yet and are seeking one with experience in labor compliance.

Milestones and Financials

We completed 31 customer-discovery interviews, built a working prototype for mobile and web, and incorporated as a Delaware C corporation with equal founder equity. We raised 18,000 dollars from friends and family in a pre-seed round, of which about 11,000 dollars remains. Our first client, a caterer with a staff of about 20, has paid us for six weeks of use, filling 37 shifts for 5,180 dollars in labor spend and generating 622 dollars in fees. We have a pool of about 140 registered workers, of whom roughly 60 have completed at least one shift. Fill time on those 37 shifts averaged 5.5 hours. Over the next twelve months we project 12 active caterers, 1,800 shifts per month by month twelve, and monthly revenue of about 30,000 dollars by year end. These projections assume rates of signup and repeat use that we have only observed with one client, and we regard them as targets rather than forecasts. Our largest costs are founder-led sales, payments and background-check fees, and part-time development help.

What We Ask For

We are applying for the competition's prize funding and mentoring. A 25,000 dollar award would let us run a structured three-month pilot with 8 to 10 additional caterers, pay for background checks and payment-processing minimums, and engage legal counsel to review worker classification rules, which we know vary by state and represent a real risk to our model. Beyond funding, we would value introductions to caterers and venue managers, advice on labor compliance, and feedback on our pricing. Our goal is to show, by the end of the pilot, repeat usage by at least six caterers and a fill rate above 90 percent, which would put us in a position to raise a seed round.